3.3 How Populists Undermine IOs: An Empirical Examination

Previously, we detailed the primary strategies populists employ to undermine IOs: withholding resources such as effort, information, and funding, and engaging in adversarial communication. While these are not the only tactics available to populists, we argue that they form a representative and impactful categorization of the most prevalent methods used to weaken IOs.

In this section, we put these claims to the test with empirical evidence. First, we illustrate that populists contribute less effort to IOs by demonstrating their lower participation rates in IMF programs compared with those of other leaders. Next, we delve into the manipulation of information, revealing how populists withhold or distort crucial data that IOs, like the World Bank, depend upon to function effectively. Finally, we analyze how populist leaders, such as Donald Trump, employ particularly combative rhetoric against the world trade system, amplifying antagonism through oppositional communication.

Our findings point to a clear pattern: Populist leaders exhibit deliberate and persistent resistance to IOs, actively working to diminish their effectiveness and credibility. These actions are not isolated or incidental but represent a concerted effort to weaken the organs of global governance. In the chapters that follow, we shift our focus to examine how IOs counter these populist attacks and seek to maintain their resilience in the face of such challenges.

3.3.1 Effort Withholding

We begin by investigating whether populist leaders systematically withhold effort from IOs, focusing specifically on their engagement with the IMF. This analysis draws on our previous research published in the *Journal of Politics* (Carnegie, Clark, and Kaya 2024), which also contains additional details. We examine whether populist leaders are less likely than their nonpopulist counterparts to participate in IMF programs. Our choice to focus on the IMF stems from its substantive importance, its role as a global lender of last resort, and the transparency of its loan operations, as outlined in the prior chapter.

The IMF occupies a unique space in global governance, providing financial support, policy advice, and technical assistance to member states. It